the republic and empire of Rome, which reached the height of its power in AD 100s. The Roman Empire included all the lands bordering the Mediterranean sea, and what are now France, England and Wales. Rome was eventually conquered by barbarians from Germany in 476, but the eastern part of the empire called the byzantine empire, lasted until 1453. It was ruled from Constantinople, formerly Byzantium and now called Istanbul.

The 600 years following the overthrow of the western Roman Empire are often called the dark ages, because learning and culture declined in this time. But from the 1000s onwards strong, independent countries began to emerge. Among them was England, which was conquered by the Normans in 1066. During this time powerful princes and nobles ruled and many of the poorer people lived in slavery. In the 1300 Europe was ravaged by the Black Death, an outbreak of bubonic plague that killed one person in four. Labour became scarce, and as a result the workers were able to demand better treatment.

In the 1400 a revival of scholarship and the arts knows as the renaissance, began in Italy. At the end that century and in the early 1500 European explorers began opening up new trading routes to Asia and the Americas were discovered and partly explored. At the same time the invention and rapid spread of printing caused a great upsurge in education. The teachings and practices of the Roman Church were challenged and the reformation began. New protestant religious sects sprang up and religious unity in Europe ended forever. Some wars of religion broke out. The 1700 saw dramatic changes. In Britain the Industrial Revolution was brought about by the invention of machines which took over much of the work formerly done by human muscles.

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